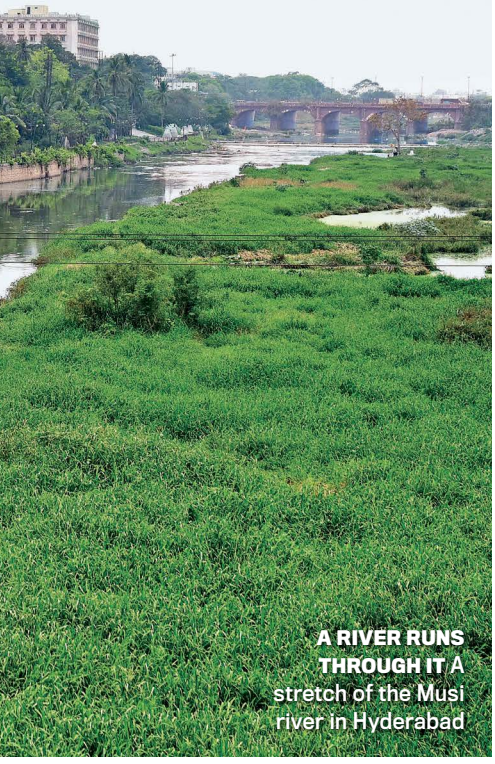


A RIVER RUNS THROUGH IT A stretch of the Musi river in Hyderabad

800 MN GALLONS A DAY OF SEWAGE WATER FLOWS INTO THE MUSI IN HYDERABAD

term as chief minister (2014-2018) by setting up the Musi River Development Corporation Limited (MRDCL) on March 25, 2017. It was meant to be the nodal agency to execute the chief minister's plan.

Work happened in fits and starts. It began with a drone survey, using digital 3-D technology, to map the topography of the riverfront—both low-lying banks and elevated areas along the stretch proposed for development. This was a span of 55 km from Gandipet to Outer Ring Road East (47 km) and Himayatsagar to Bapughat (8 km) in the city. The river boundary and the buffer zone were demarcated, and beautification works such as etching out walkways and landscaping were taken up on the edges of the Musi, at Nagole, Chaderghat and Muslim Jung bridge. Trash barriers were installed at 10 places to collect the floating waste from the river, hydraulic excavators dredged the silt, and spraying and fogging operations were launched to quell the mosquito menace and the stench.

In March 2022, K.T. Rama Rao, KCR's son and state municipal administration minister, announced in the state assembly that action had been initiated to engage consultants who would prepare a comprehensive master development plan and a detailed project report. This would include riverfront development, sprucing up roads on either side of the river and building skyways where roads were not possible. The beautification would not come cheap. The 14 bridges to be constructed across the river would cost Rs 545 crore, the skyway Rs 4,240 crore, the four radial roads Rs 2,354 crore, the entire project adding up to a staggering Rs 8,973 crore.

However, poised at the brink of another assembly election, nothing will come in the way of KCR's grand plan—not even the criticism that it is a drain on the exchequer. "We want to make sure that it becomes another landmark development in the city," KTR had assured the legislature last year. The minister also said the government was working out the modalities to mobilise finances.

Seen in totality, it's a complex project. The Musi development plan aims to clean the river, beautify the riverscape and ease transportation around it. The government has planned sewage treatment plants (STPs) at different locations costing Rs 3,866 crore to ensure only 100 per cent treated water is released into the river. Another 36 decentralised STPs are being added to the existing 20 to control the stench and check pollutants. About 10,000 encroachments on the riverbed have been identified for removal. Over the years, debris and garbage have been dumped into the river to create land pockets that can then be sold as real estate. The state road transport corporation has put up a bus terminal and the Hyderabad metro rail corporation too has encroached on such 'reclamations'. Both commercial accommodation and slums have come up with the connivance of government departments.

Extracting a sylvan landscape out of all that is a real ask—that's why there's no dearth of sceptics. Not only do they say the ideas mostly remain on paper, their reading of the plan itself is that it's superficially idealistic and lacks a grounding in what's actually needed. Environmental policy consultant Narasimha Reddy Donthi, for instance, feels KCR's grand plans for the Musi will be unrealisable unless the city's water and sewage systems are separated, and the flow of industrial effluents stopped. He points to the need to instal an adequate number of effluent treatment plants and relocating slums from hazardous areas. G. Kishan Reddy, Union tourism minister and Secunderabad MP, adds: "Only some cosmetic changes have been initiated to impress voters. That's why both banks of the river see flooding year after year following heavy rains."

The state, in turn, accuses the Centre of duplicity, being generous to other river-cleaning projects like the Ganga, but not the Musi. "Grants promised under the Jal Shakti Abhiyan and by the National River Conservation Directorate have not come," says an MRDC official. Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) MLA D. Sudheer Reddy, who completed his three-year tenure as MRDC chairman in February, says "KCR has spent over Rs 40 crore from state funds to restore the Musi's glory. Had it not been for financial constraints, the project would have progressed fast." State Congress president A. Revanth Reddy begs to differ. "Given KCR's ways," he claims, "the Musi project will just be used as a money-spinner for the BRS in an election year." The river, clearly, has to wash a lot of dirty linen. ■